Definition

Influenza (commonly known as Flu) is an acute infection of the respiratory tract. It is caused by the influenza viruses. Influenza tends to spread very rapidly.

Causative organism

Influenza virus are 3 types. Namely A, B, C

Mode of transmission - Influenza spreads mainly from person by droplet infection created by sneezing, Coughing or talking. The portal of entry of the virus is the respiratory tract.

Incubation period - 18 – 72 hours

Clinical manifestations

1. Fever
2. Chills
3. Aches
4. Pains
5. Cough
6. Generalized weakness

Complications - Pneumonia

Treatment

Antiviral drugs: These drugs may also modify the severity of influenza. If started with in 24-48 hours of onset of illness

Control Measures

- Avoidance of crowded places
- Good ventilation of public buildings
- Covering the face when coughing and sneezing with handkerchief or cloth
- Isolation of cases of influenza

Diphtheria

Definition

Diphtheria is an acute infections, caused by the exotoxin of diphtheria bacilli. The disease attacks mainly the throat, tonsils, larynx or nose. Where the baccilli produces a grayish-white membrane which spread in to the air passages.

Causative organism

Corynebacterium diphtheria caused by exotoxin of diphtheria bacilli.

Mode of transmission

1. Droplet infection.
2. Infected cutaneous lesions.
3. Infective object or dust, contaminated with nasopharyngeal secretions.

Incubation period - 2-6 days occasionally longer

Clinical manifestations

The onset of symptoms is typically gradual. Most common presenting symptoms are

- Sore throat
- Malaise
- Cervical lymphadenopathy
- Low grade fever.
- Pharyngo tonsillar diphtheria - sore throat and difficult in swallowing
- Mild erythema is the earliest pharyngeal finding
- Isolated spots of gray and white exudate.
- Membranous pharyngitis
- Massive swelling of the tonsils, Uvula, cervical lymph nodes, submandibular region, and anterior neck (the so-called "bull neck" of toxic diphtheria).
- Aspiration of the membrane can lead to suffocation.
- Laryngeal diphtheria causes obstructive croup stridor and eventually asphyxia.
- Respiratory stridor may ensue, leading to respiratory insufficiency and death.

Complications

Diphtheria toxin can lead to

- Damage of the heart (myocarditis)

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